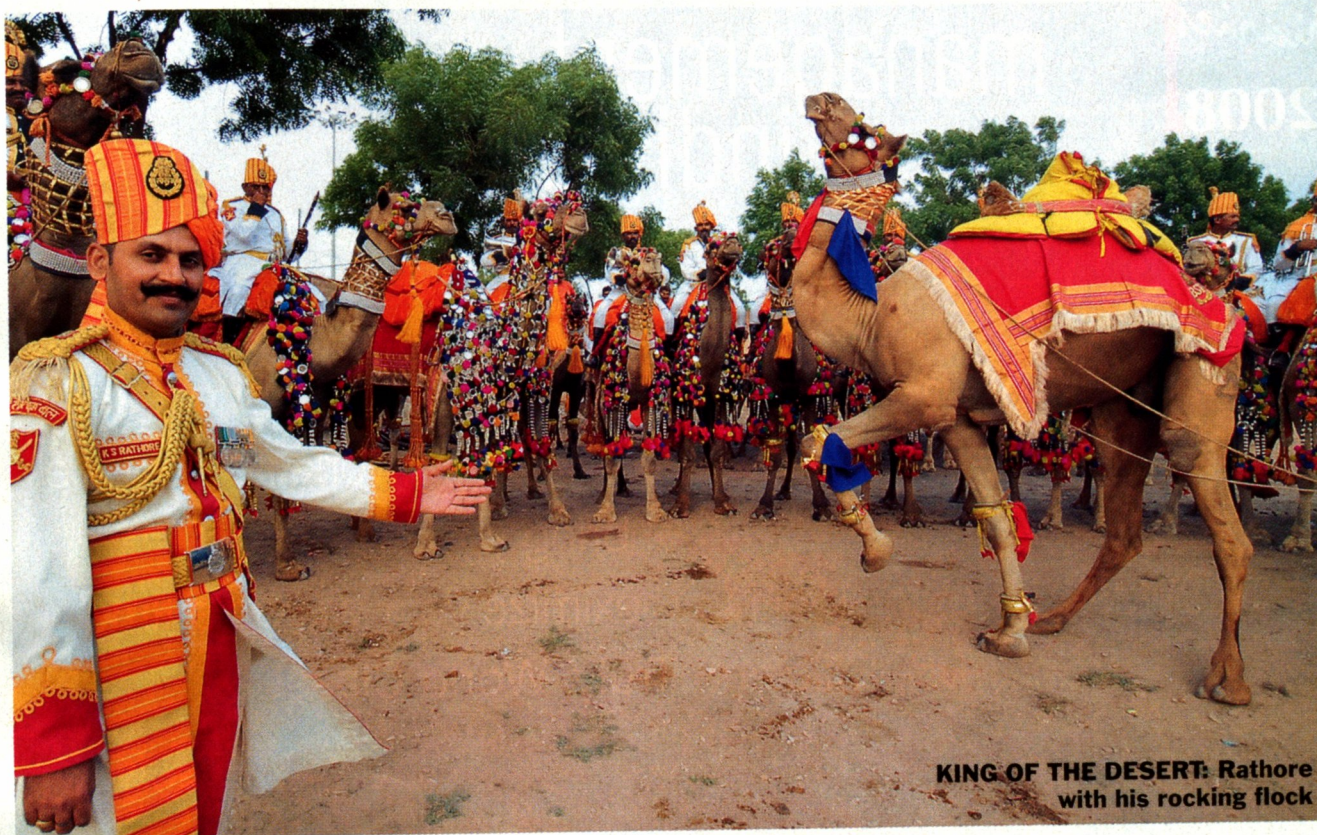




KING OF THE DESERT: Rathore with his rocking flock

Four-legged Force

With leggy dancers prancing to popular songs, the band of camels is today an integral part of BSF

■ **By Rohit Parihar**

Oneupmanship is something we have all encountered but have you ever heard of camelmanship? If you haven't, then you can be forgiven for a shortfall in knowledge. After all, it is not everyday that one encounters camels vying with each other to excel in doing stunts or shaking a leg to the beat of the drums.

In fact India is probably the only country in the world where its Border Security Force (BSF) not only does the job of protecting our frontiers but also trains camels to be part of a full-fledged band. The force is the single biggest employer of camels in the country with a flock of 1,100. The animal has been part of the border force for ages with its ability to walk on sand and stay without water for days. But it was only in 1986 that K.S. Rathore, a horse rider of repute who took over as BSF's inspector general of police in Jodhpur, floated the idea of a camel band. While training the animals to march to the tune of the band, the trainers realised the potential of making them dance too. Since then, the camel band has been amongst the most entertaining of shows in the state, the dance of the heavily-ornamented and bridled camels being the highlight.

Of the 1,100 animals that the border force possesses,



about 60 are Jaisalmeri and Bikaneri fine breed, considered capable of training others in patrolling and other ceremonial activities like racing and stunts. Of these 60, two are chosen to undergo a year-long training in dance and a third one is trained as a stand-by.

Camels have played an important part in India's defence history. In 1971 war, there were 100 casualties amongst them. "Until then, the army had its own ones too but thereafter, the task was shifted to BSF," says Kamal Singh Rathore, deputy commandant, Jodhpur, who looks after the training of the animals.

The training of camels, males only, starts at the age of five and the animals retire at 12 though their lifespan is about 25-30 years. With poor memory and a herd mentality, they are trained in batches of six along with a few trained ones since novices tend to copy the activities of their trained counterparts. After a week of schooling, a saddle is harnessed on their back and weight training is initiated gradually. A rider gets to sit on his animal only after one month and a ceremonial camel is ready within a few months' time.

Racing and dancing camels are a big hit during the state's many cultural festivals. With demand for trainers now coming from as far as Scotland and Oman, the animal is set to conquer more than the desert.